

Before You Became a Memory

Chapter 1: The Echo Before You

I don't remember what the sky looked like before you.

Or maybe I do, but it doesn't feel real anymore.

There are sounds I've forgotten since that night—the ordinary ones. Like the buzz of the streetlight outside my window, or the hum of a ceiling fan spinning lazily above me. But there's one sound that never faded: the echo of your laugh, just before I turned around and saw you for the first time.

You were leaning against the far wall of a bookstore, flipping through a worn-out poetry collection like the world wasn't spinning. Like you were a part of something slower. Calmer. Truer.

I wasn't supposed to be there that night. I took the wrong train, or maybe the right one—I still don't know. All I do know is that I ended up on that quiet street where nothing extraordinary ever happened, except for you.

You didn't notice me at first.

And that gave me time to notice everything about you.

The way your fingers paused on a line, as if the poem had just told you something only you could understand. The way your eyes softened like clouds before a summer storm. There was a stillness around you that felt... intentional.

And just when I turned to leave, afraid of turning a beautiful maybe into an awkward now—

You looked up.

And smiled.

That's it.

That's where the story begins.

That smile.

Chapter 2: Rain in Reverse

I remember it like rain running backward—

like watching the drops lift from the pavement, shimmer in mid-air, and return to the clouds.

That's how the memory plays in my mind—never forward, never fading. Always returning.

It was the kind of night where nothing extraordinary was supposed to happen. The city had already gone quiet. The cafés were pulling down their shutters. Streetlights blinked like tired eyes. I walked with no direction, heart a little heavier than usual, not because something bad had happened—but because nothing had.

There's a loneliness in routine.

A quiet ache in the days that feel like copies of each other.

I didn't know I was about to meet the person who would undo all of that.

I walked past the same flower shop I always passed. The same bookstore. The same coffee stand that never made my drink right. But then I heard it. The sound that would change something unnamed inside me. A laugh. Your laugh.

Not loud. Not sharp. But whole—like it belonged to a soul unafraid of the world.

And it drew me in like gravity.

You were standing under the dim light of a flickering sign, talking to an old man about books that “felt too heavy to be fiction.” That was the first sentence I ever heard you say. And I remember thinking—who describes books like that?

You were wearing something simple. A navy coat, a scarf you kept adjusting as if it never sat right on your shoulder. And your hair—slightly undone by the breeze—moved like it belonged in a slow-motion film. I don’t remember what I was wearing, only that I suddenly felt out of place in it.

I don’t remember deciding to walk in, but I did.

I told myself I needed a book I didn’t plan to read.

But the truth was—I didn’t want the moment to pass.

Inside, the bookstore smelled like old pages and soft endings. A quiet kind of warm. You moved between aisles like you’d been there before, but the way you paused told me you still read with wonder. I watched you touch the spines of novels like they were memories, not stories.

And I thought to myself, people like you still exist?

You noticed me then.

You didn’t smile right away. You studied me the way someone studies a book’s first line—curious, cautious, wondering if it was worth continuing. Then slowly, you smiled like the answer was yes.

I asked something stupid. I think it was about the book you were holding.

You said, “This one feels like a conversation that ends before it’s ready to.”

I didn’t know what you meant, not fully. But something about that sentence... stayed.

You didn’t speak the way most people did. You didn’t just talk—you revealed. Every sentence felt like it carried a little piece of who you were. And I—I had never met someone like that. Someone who made silence feel full instead of empty. Someone who made me want to be seen for the first time.

We talked for fifteen minutes. Maybe less. But something about that time bent reality. It felt longer. Like we’d skipped over small talk and walked straight into a memory.

I didn’t ask for your name.

You didn’t offer it either.

Maybe we were both afraid that saying it out loud would break the moment.

I left with a book I didn’t buy and a feeling I couldn’t name.

And when I walked back into the night, it had started to rain.

But it didn’t feel cold.

Didn't feel heavy.

Didn't feel like rain at all.

It felt like something beginning.

Like fate gently tapping me on the shoulder.

Chapter 3: That One Room, That One Song

Some places never leave you.

Not because of how they looked, but because of what happened inside them—what was said, unsaid, felt. There's this one room I still carry with me. It wasn't special by design. Four faded walls, dim ceiling light, a half-broken fan that ticked instead of spinning, and a window that never opened fully. But that night, you were in it.

And that made all the difference.

It was a week after our first meeting. I wasn't sure if I'd ever see you again. I wasn't even sure if you were real or just one of those dream-like memories we invent when the world gets too loud. But then you texted.

Not a long message. Just three words:

"Still thinking sometimes."

You didn't say of you, and you didn't need to. I knew.

We met again in that room. My friend's apartment, third floor, two flights of creaking stairs and no elevator. Everyone else was scattered across the flat—music playing softly, a few conversations happening in corners, bottles clinking, someone lighting a cigarette near the open balcony. But all I remember is you walking in.

Same coat. Different scarf. Same eyes.

You didn't look for anyone else. Just me. And you smiled like we were picking up a sentence from the last page we left off.

"Do you remember the poem I was reading?" you asked.

I didn't. But I said yes.

You laughed. "Liar."

And then we found a quiet corner of the room. It didn't matter where—we would've found that moment anywhere. The lights flickered slightly. Someone played an old love song from the speaker. Something soft, something from the past.

And without thinking, you said:

"This song reminds me of a version of myself I've never been."

I wanted to ask what that meant.

But I didn't.

Because something about the way you said it felt too delicate to question.

So I just nodded. And I told you the truth.

“You feel like a page I don’t want to turn yet.”

You looked at me for a long time after that. I couldn’t tell if you were about to say something profound or leave the room. Instead, you asked:

“Can I show you something?”

You pulled out a folded napkin from your pocket. On it were scribbled lines—messy, poetic, raw. Your handwriting danced across it like you were racing against time when you wrote it. It read:

“I don’t want the whole sky—

just a corner of it

where someone remembers my name

even when I forget it myself.”

You looked away as I read it, embarrassed like it was too much. But it wasn’t. It was just enough.

That night, we didn’t touch. We didn’t kiss. We didn’t make promises.

We just listened—to the music, to the fan ticking, to the silence filling the space between two people who didn’t want to fall in love, but were already in too deep.

I left that room feeling like I knew you in ways I couldn’t explain.

And the song?

I’ve never heard it again.

Not because I forgot it—

But because some songs should only play once, in one room, with one person.

Chapter 4: When My World Paused

There’s a strange kind of silence that comes right before your world changes.

Not dramatic. Not loud.

Just... still. Like the universe holding its breath.

That’s what it felt like the next time we met.

It was unplanned, again. But I was starting to think maybe none of this was accidental. Maybe some people aren’t part of your schedule—they’re part of your fate.

I was sitting alone in a café I didn’t even like. The coffee was too bitter, the chairs were uncomfortable, and the light from the windows always made me feel exposed. But that day, it didn’t matter.

You walked in like the outside world didn’t follow you. Like time slipped off your shoulders at the door. Your coat was unbuttoned. Your eyes were tired, but not sad—like you’d been thinking about something for too long.

You saw me. Paused.

And then smiled like you didn't expect me, but you were glad I was there.

You sat across from me without asking, the way people do when they already feel like they belong.

"Do you ever feel like you're living out of order?" you asked. "Like your memories are happening before the moments actually do?"

I just looked at you.

Because yes.

That's exactly what you felt like—something I remembered before you even arrived.

We didn't talk about big things that day. Not directly. We spoke around them, like we were afraid the truth might be too fragile to look at. But underneath every sentence, there was something heavier:

We were both running from something.

You, from the weight of all the lives you didn't get to live. Me, from the life I was tired of repeating.

But sitting there, across that cheap wooden table, it felt like none of that mattered.

Because you weren't just a person—I was beginning to realize.

You were a moment.

One of those rare, shimmering pauses in life when everything aligns for no reason other than you were meant to meet.

You doodled on a napkin again. This time it was a spiral, turning inward. You said nothing about it, but when you left, you folded it up and handed it to me.

I still have it.

I didn't ask where you were going that day. And you didn't say.

Some part of me knew not to ask.

Some part of me feared that the magic was fragile—that naming it might break it.

So I just watched you go.

And as soon as the door closed behind you, the world restarted.

No music. No dialogue. No sound.

Just the soft ache of everything returning to normal,
and me realizing

that I didn't want normal anymore.

Chapter 5: She Carried a Season

She didn't walk into people's lives.

She drifted in like a change in weather—quiet, invisible at first, then suddenly everything felt different.

She wasn't the kind of person you could describe in simple words. There was no list that could explain her, no summary that could capture the weight of her presence. She wasn't just beautiful. She wasn't just kind. She wasn't just sad.

She was all of it—woven together like threads of a season that didn't belong to any calendar.

And for me, she was autumn.

Not because of the way she dressed, though she did wear warm colors that looked like sunset. Not because of the way her laughter sounded like wind through dying leaves. But because being near her made everything inside me fall, slowly and without warning.

She carried endings with her, but not in a way that hurt.

In a way that made you appreciate what you were about to lose.

One evening, we sat on a bench outside the old library—our conversations never scheduled, never formal. Just moments we kept stumbling into like old songs on shuffle. She was watching the sky again, the way she always did when her thoughts got too loud.

"I don't like the idea of forever," she whispered. "It feels dishonest."

I turned to her. "What do you mean?"

"Forever pretends that things don't end. But I think the best things always do. That's what makes them precious."

I didn't know how to respond.

Because deep down, I wanted her to stay.

I wanted her to be the one thing that didn't end.

But maybe she already knew she wouldn't.

She would never say it. Never write it. Never explain it. But she moved through the world like someone who had already accepted that nothing she touched would last—not because she broke things, but because she made them too beautiful to keep.

Some people build futures.

She built moments.

That night, she showed me a notebook she carried with her—pages filled with half-thoughts, questions, pieces of dreams. She didn't ask me to read them. She just opened it and let me see. That trust, that silence—it meant more than any confession.

I saw one page that said:

"Don't remember me for how I left.

Remember me for the color I brought into rooms

you didn't know were dim."

She closed the notebook before I could say anything.

And I realized, maybe she wasn't meant to be understood.

Maybe she was meant to be felt—like the first chill in the air that tells you summer is over. Like the first leaf that falls before the rest follow.

She didn't belong to me.

She belonged to the feeling of almost.

And yet, every time I saw her, I forgot how to protect myself from wanting more.

Chapter 6: Unspoken Fireworks

We never said we were in love.

There were no declarations. No dramatic moments under streetlights. No accidental confessions during midnight calls.

But the silence between us had a shape, and it pulsed like a secret trying to escape.

One night, we went to a rooftop party. It was the kind of place neither of us belonged in—loud music, people we barely knew, laughter too rehearsed. But you showed up anyway, leaning on the edge of the railing like you'd been there before, watching the sky instead of the crowd.

I found you in that quiet corner again.

You always carried silence with you, like it was a language you preferred.

"You okay?" I asked.

You didn't answer right away. Instead, you looked up at the sky and said, "It's strange how we light up the sky for things that eventually fade."

I followed your gaze.

Fireworks.

Exploding above the city like temporary stars.

Loud. Beautiful. And gone within seconds.

"I think we're like that," you added. "Some people are just meant to be fireworks in each other's lives. Not candles. Not flames. Just... bursts."

That hurt more than it should've.

Because I didn't want you to be a burst.

I wanted you to be the quiet after.

Later that night, we sat at the edge of the rooftop, our legs dangling over the city lights. The sky had returned to stillness, and the silence between us felt heavier than usual. You leaned your head on my shoulder, and for the first time, I didn't think about what it meant. I just let it happen.

There was so much we didn't say.

So much I wanted to ask—

Why do you disappear some nights without a trace?

Why do your eyes sometimes look like you're already mourning something?

But I stayed silent.

Because maybe I knew the answers would undo me.

You hummed a tune softly. A sad one. You didn't sing the words. You just let the melody fill the space. It felt like a song for two people who were falling in love but already knew it had an expiration date.

That night, you asked me:

"Do you believe people can be connected even if they're never meant to stay?"

I said yes.

And I meant it.

Because I was beginning to feel like maybe your presence in my life wasn't meant to lead to something permanent.

Maybe it was meant to shake me.

To open something.

To teach me how deeply I could feel.

And still—

Still I hoped.

Still I wondered.

What if the fireworks didn't end?

What if this was more?

But some things burn brightest when they aren't held too tightly.

And maybe you already knew that.

Chapter 7: Letters I Never Sent

I started writing to you long before I knew I'd lose you.

Not texts. Not emails.

Letters.

Handwritten. On real paper. The kind that folds and creases and carries weight—like the feelings I couldn't say out loud.

None of them were ever given to you.

They lived in a drawer, sealed in envelopes without addresses. They weren't meant for the post. They were meant for the parts of me that didn't know how to let go, even when you hadn't gone yet.

The first letter I wrote was after our third meeting.

I had just walked home through the rain—my hoodie soaked, my shoes squeaking, my heart somehow louder than the storm. You had touched my hand by accident while reaching for something on the shelf, and even though it lasted no longer than a second, I felt it for hours.

The letter began:

"I don't know what this is yet,

but it feels like I've been waiting for it without knowing I was waiting."

Another letter came after that night on the rooftop—after the fireworks, after the silence.

"If I say your name out loud, I feel like I'll wake up from something.

And I'm not ready to wake up."

I wrote dozens over time. Each one capturing something I couldn't admit:

That I was falling in love with someone who might never be mine.

That your eyes had become a place I looked to for direction.

That your silence was beginning to say more than your words.

And yet, I never gave them to you.

Because I was afraid.

Afraid that you'd read them and smile politely.

Afraid you'd fold them and tuck them away like a compliment.

Afraid you'd hand them back and say, "I didn't ask for this."

So I let them collect like seasons in my drawer—

unopened summers, unsent winters, autumns that smelled like your scarf.

I started to realize that I wasn't writing to you anymore.

I was writing to the version of you I built in my head.

The version who stayed.

The one who didn't leave rooms without a goodbye.

The one who saw me not just as someone passing through, but someone who could've been home.

And maybe that was my mistake.

Maybe I loved the idea of you more than the version who stood in front of me, holding back.

Maybe I thought my letters could make you stay, even if they never reached you.

Still, I wrote.

Because putting my feelings into ink felt like the only way to keep them from drowning me.

Because the words knew where to go, even when I didn't.

And now—

Now that you're gone—

Now that all I have is your shadow—

These letters are the only things that still feel real.

Chapter 8: Haunting Ghost

You were gone.

Not in the dramatic way people expect—no final message, no door slammed behind you, no tear-streaked goodbye in the rain.

You just... drifted out of my days.

At first, it felt like space.

Then it started to feel like absence.

And finally, it began to feel like haunting.

You became a ghost I couldn't exorcise.

Not from my heart. Not from my memory.

Not even from the spaces you'd never been in—because somehow, your echo followed me into rooms you never touched.

I saw you in the shape of strangers' shadows.

Heard your voice in songs that never played before.

Felt your warmth in the sun on my back, even on days when the sky was cold.

The worst part wasn't that you left.

The worst part was that I never got to watch you go.

You slipped out of my life the way breath slips from lungs—quietly, slowly, until I couldn't remember the moment I stopped feeling alive.

I kept waking up thinking I had forgotten something.

A name. A time. A date.

But it was always you.

I'd open my messages expecting one from you—even after days, weeks, months.

Even after I deleted your number. Even after I told myself I'd moved on.

But grief is never obedient.

It returns at the worst times—like 2:17 AM, when the world is too quiet.

Or when a song plays that I didn't know you'd left behind for me to suffer through.

You weren't a person anymore.

You were a presence.

You were the air in the wrong room.

The chill in the middle of a summer day.

You haunted me not because of what you said, but because of everything you didn't.

Because you never told me what we were.

Because you left me with unfinished thoughts, unsaid goodbyes, and a love that didn't know how to die quietly.

Some ghosts don't wear white.

They don't float. They don't rattle chains.

They just exist inside your chest, making it harder to breathe.

And you were mine.

I tried to bury you under new faces.

Tried to overwrite you with louder laughs, safer eyes, simpler hearts.

But no one could erase the part of me that still turned toward the door—just in case it was you.

Because part of me still believes...

You were never supposed to be a ghost.

You were supposed to stay.

Chapter 9: If Timing Were a Person

If timing were a person, I think I'd hate them.

They'd be the type who shows up late to every important moment, spilling coffee on your hope, whispering "not yet" just when you're ready to give everything.

Because with you—

It was never the feeling that was wrong.

It was always the timing.

You and I... we met in the space between versions of ourselves.

You were healing from something you never named.

I was just beginning to understand what I needed.

We were both half-finished.

And maybe that's why it felt so whole—for a while.

But love doesn't wait for people to be ready.

It arrives in its own time.

And when you're not ready, it feels more like a burden than a blessing.

There were nights I stayed up, replaying every word we exchanged, trying to find the exact moment when it started to unravel. But the truth is, there was no unraveling.

It was never stitched together properly to begin with.

We mistook intensity for permanence.

We mistook magic for alignment.

And in the quiet moments—when the world faded and it was just you and me—I thought we had beaten the odds.

But then the world came back.

Louder. Harsher. Realer.

And I realized—

You were always half-looking at the door.

Not because you didn't care.

But because you knew what I didn't:

You were never meant to stay.

I started blaming myself for the way things fell apart.

Was I too much? Too vulnerable? Too fast?

But the more I untangled it, the clearer it became.

We weren't the wrong people.

We were just people in the wrong moment.

You were meant to cross my path. To awaken something. To burn a hole in my timeline I'll never be able to patch.

But you weren't meant to walk it with me.

If timing were a person, I'd beg them for one more hour.

Not to change anything.

Just to tell you—without hesitation, without fear—

That I would've stayed.

Even in the wrong time.

Even when you wouldn't.

Chapter 10: Where the Silence Fell in Love

It wasn't in a kiss.

It wasn't in a confession, a touch, a shared song, or even a look.

It was in the silence.

That space between our words where something unspoken grew like roots under the surface—quiet, unseen, but strong enough to shift everything above it.

People talk about falling in love like it's a loud thing. Like fireworks and pounding hearts and moments that beg to be remembered. But with you, it was soft. So soft I didn't notice it at first.

I thought I was just comfortable.

I thought I was just drawn to your calm, your quiet, your contradiction.

But now I know—

It was in the silence between us that love began to speak.

Like that night we sat in the corner of the café—neither of us talking. No music, no noise, just the sound of spoons clinking and the slow ticking of the clock on the wall. I looked at you, and you were just... breathing. Existing. Lost in thought.

And I loved you for it.

Not for what you said.

Not for what you did.

But for the fact that even when you gave me nothing, it felt like everything.

That's how I knew.

That's when the silence fell in love with you.

It was in the pauses you let linger without rushing to fill them.

It was in the way you listened like you didn't just want to reply—you wanted to understand.

It was in the stillness of sitting beside you and feeling like the world didn't need to move.

I didn't realize how rare that was until later.

Until I sat beside others and waited for that feeling to return.

It never did.

You taught me that love isn't always loud.

It doesn't always scream in declarations or arrive with grand gestures.

Sometimes, it's just two people,

breathing in the same moment,

and not needing anything more.

But silence is tricky.

It can be sacred, or it can be empty.

After you left, it became the second kind.

Not peaceful. Not poetic. Just hollow.

Now, silence isn't where love lives.
It's where memory echoes.
And every quiet moment I once loved
now reminds me
of what's missing.

Chapter 11: Her Absence Is a Place

Her absence wasn't emptiness.
It was presence.
Louder, heavier, sharper than her being ever was.
You don't realize how much space someone takes up until they leave.
And then suddenly, they're everywhere.
Not as a memory—
as a place.
Her absence became the empty half of the bed I stopped rolling into.
The missing laugh in a room full of jokes.
The way I'd make two cups of tea out of habit, and then watch one grow cold.
I didn't just miss her.
I stood inside the shape she left behind.
There were echoes in my apartment that didn't exist before her. Footsteps that weren't there,
breaths that weren't mine. Sometimes I'd open a drawer and find nothing—yet swear I smelled her
perfume in the fabric of my old clothes.
Grief plays tricks on you.
It doesn't come all at once.
It arrives in waves. In corners. In silence.
And every time I walked into a room she'd once been in, I could feel the outline of her like sunlight
after clouds. Not warm, not gentle. Just there—unavoidable.
I caught myself whispering things out loud, just in case she could still hear them:
"Do you still think of that night?"
"Did you ever really stay?"
"Do you know I still look for you in crowds?"
But the walls never answered.
Because her absence wasn't just emotional.

It had geography. It had walls.

It took up space in the way I walked through life.

I didn't change the sheets.

Didn't rearrange the furniture.

Didn't erase the playlist we made that one night when the lights went out and we danced in the dark, laughing like we weren't two people already halfway to goodbye.

I kept everything exactly the same.

Because moving anything felt like admitting she wasn't coming back.

And I wasn't ready.

Still not sure if I ever will be.